Transparent City

Version 1.0, September 2026

Flock by the Numbers

What five American cities paid Flock Safety according to public records, what happened to reported vehicle theft while the cameras ran, and what happened where they were switched off.

Data through June 2026. Methodology fixed before the analysis was run.

$5.19M

paid by San Francisco to Flock Safety for cameras and drones, from the city checkbook

−54%

reported San Francisco vehicle thefts, 2023 to 2025, reproduced from raw incident data

7

cities in the pre-registered monthly panel, 2022 to 2026

7 + 3

months of data after Austin and Denver switched their networks off, with no rebound so far

Key findings

$5.19M

San Francisco has paid Flock Safety $5,191,350 to date: $3,935,000 on the 400-camera license plate reader contract and $1,228,000 on a drone contract that began in September 2025. The camera program was funded largely by a $17.3 million state grant. Every dollar is visible in the city checkbook and matches independent reporting.

−54%

Reported vehicle thefts in San Francisco fell 54 percent from 2023 to 2025, from 8,985 to 4,143. We reproduce from raw incident data the figure the San Francisco Standard reported from SFPD data.

−49.5% vs −36.6%

Over months 7 to 18 after deployment, San Francisco's reported thefts fell faster than in every comparison city; Oakland, the other dense network, fell 41.9 percent. Austin's 40-camera pilot tracked Chicago and Seattle closely.

No rebound so far

Austin and Denver switched their networks off. Reported thefts kept falling in both, as fast as or faster than in comparison cities, across seven clean months in Austin and three in Denver. The windows are short and the page says so.

−50% / −59%

Blocks within 250 meters of a camera fell 50 percent; blocks 500 meters or more from every camera fell 59 percent. The decline is citywide, not concentrated near cameras. If the cameras contributed, the geography is more consistent with case-closing than with deterrence at the corner.

18 of 18

Every San Francisco neighborhood with 200 or more reported thefts in 2023 logged fewer in 2025, with declines between 37 and 69 percent.

7	**54**	**30,417**	**333**
cities in the monthly panel	months, January 2022 to June 2026	geocoded San Francisco theft incidents (390 of 30,807 lacked coordinates)	mapped SFPD camera positions, about 83 percent of the network
12	**f093c5df**		
official open datasets, all public	methodology committed before analysis		

Abstract. Flock Safety's license plate readers have been cancelled by dozens of cities since 2025 and kept by others. This report sets aside claims from both the company and its critics and asks only what public records show. Using city open-data portals, we assemble every payment San Francisco and Denver made to Flock Safety, verify that Chicago has made none, and construct a seven-city monthly panel of reported motor vehicle theft (2022 to 2026) spanning two cities that deployed dense Flock networks (San Francisco, Oakland), two that deployed and later shut them down (Austin, Denver), and three Flock-free comparisons (Chicago, New York, Seattle).

The record supports three findings. **First, the cost is small.** San Francisco has paid Flock Safety $5.19 million in total, $3.94 million of it on the 400-camera contract, and we reproduce from raw incident data the figure, reported by the San Francisco Standard from SFPD data, that reported vehicle thefts fell 54 percent from 2023 to 2025. **Second, where Flock networks are dense, reported theft fell faster than in comparison cities.** San Francisco fell 49.5 percent and Oakland 41.9 percent over matched windows, against declines of 12.6 to 36.6 percent in the three comparison cities. The panel estimate is an 18 percent association (permutation p = 0.16), sharpening to 26 percent (p = 0.017) when the 40-camera Austin network is excluded per pre-registered robustness. **Third, switching the networks off produced no detectable rebound within the short windows available.** Reported theft kept falling in Austin and in Denver. The conclusion the record supports is that Flock's cameras are a cheap tool that coincided with outsized declines where densely deployed, that removal has not so far coincided with any measurable increase in vehicle theft, and that the live disputes are about governance, because the public record does not settle effectiveness either way.

The story in brief

Two American cities switched off their Flock Safety camera networks in the past year, and reported vehicle theft in both kept falling. We have not found a published comparison of theft trends in cities that shut Flock networks off. Austin ended its contract in June 2025 and logged 12.7 percent fewer thefts per month over the following seven months, a faster decline than Chicago, New York, or Seattle over the same period. Denver removed all 110 cameras in March 2026, and the three months since show no rebound. The most alarming claim made on the cameras’ behalf, that removing them invites a crime wave, has no support in the first real-world tests, which are short.

The cities that kept dense networks paid little for them. San Francisco has paid Flock Safety $5.19 million in total, about 0.03 percent of one year’s $15.9 billion city budget, and its reported vehicle thefts fell 54 percent from 2023 to 2025, a decline that outpaced every comparison city in our panel. Whether the cameras caused any part of that decline cannot be established from public data, and this report does not claim it. What can be shown is the full ledger: what was paid, what happened, and what happened where the cameras came down.

Part one: The setting

Why the question matters, what the country was doing to vehicle theft at the same time, and what the cities actually paid.

1. Why this report exists

Flock Safety operates automated license plate readers (ALPRs) for more than 5,000 law enforcement agencies. Since 2025, reporting on immigration-related lookups through Flock's national search network, an Illinois Secretary of State audit finding that Customs and Border Protection accessed Illinois cameras through an undisclosed pilot, and a string of officer-misuse cases have driven dozens of cities to cancel contracts. The exact national tally (30, 53, or 80 cities, depending on the tracker) comes from advocacy groups and is not relied on here. Austin canceled in June 2025. Denver removed all 110 cameras (111 by one count) when its contract expired on March 31, 2026. San Francisco, which deployed 400 cameras in 2024, and Oakland, which renewed its 290-camera contract in December 2025, kept theirs.

Both sides of this fight argue mostly from anecdotes and tallies. What has been missing is the middle layer of record: the contracts and payments in city checkbooks, and the crime series in city open-data portals, analyzed under rules fixed in advance. Transparent City ingests exactly these datasets for its covered cities, and that is the entire contribution of this report. We claim no access to Flock, no access to police departments, and nothing that cannot be re-queried by any reader.

A note on posture. We undertook this analysis expecting the data to be broadly favorable to Flock, and much of it is. But the methodology (section 4) was committed to our repository before any outcome statistic was computed, and it binds us to publish whatever came out, including the finding in section 8 that undercuts the strongest pro-camera argument. Nothing in this report should be read as a causal claim; the design supports careful association language only.

2. National context: theft was falling everywhere

This is the single most important caveat, so it comes first. Reported motor vehicle theft in the United States fell dramatically over exactly the period Flock networks expanded. The FBI estimates the national theft rate dropped 19.4 percent in 2024, and the National Insurance Crime Bureau reports a further 23 percent decline in the first half of 2025. A major driver was the subsidence of the 2022 to 2023 Kia and Hyundai theft wave after manufacturer software fixes, which hit cities unevenly. Colorado additionally felonized all motor vehicle theft in July 2023, before Denver's cameras went up.

−19.4%

The one-year drop in the national motor vehicle theft rate in 2024, per the FBI. The National Insurance Crime Bureau counted 17 percent fewer thefts that year, the largest annual decrease it has recorded in 40 years, and every finding below sits on top of that wave.

Every city in our panel shows a large decline, with or without Flock. Any analysis that shows a chart of theft falling after camera installation and stops there is misleading. The questions this report can answer are whether Flock cities fell *faster than comparable cities*, and what happened at the off-switches.

3. Follow the money

We queried each city's payment and contract datasets for vendor names matching "FLOCK" (excluding one unrelated 2007 individual and a Chicago nonprofit containing the word). The results below are verbatim from the portals.

CITY	SOURCE DATASET	WHAT IT SHOWS	AMOUNT
San Francisco	cqi5-hm2d (contracts)	“POL - ALPR subscription,” Flock Safety, term 2024-02-20 to 2027-02-19	$3,935,000 agreed, $3,935,000 paid
	cqi5-hm2d (contracts)	“POL - Flock Aerodome DFR” (drone as first responder), term 2025-09-22 to 2027-09-21	$2,484,532 agreed, $1,228,000 paid
	n9pm-xkyq (payments)	Vouchers paid to FLOCK SAFETY: FY2024 $1,535,000; FY2025 $21,600; FY2026 $2,434,750; FY2027 $1,200,000	$5,191,350 paid
Denver	wnau-xrqi (checkbook)	Six payments to FLOCK SAFETY, October to December 2025, categorized “Computer services”	$179,909
Chicago	s4vu-giwb (payments)	Zero payments to Flock Safety or Flock Group. The Chicago Police Department’s ALPR vendor is Motorola Solutions (Vigilant)	$0
Oakland	none queryable	No queryable checkbook on the open-data portal. The initial 290-camera network was funded by the California Highway Patrol; the city’s own two-year renewal, approved December 2025, is roughly $2 million per council record	about $2M (cited)
Austin	none queryable	No queryable checkbook on the open-data portal. Roughly 40 fixed cameras under a pilot that ended 2025-06-30, per council records and press	not available (cited)

Retrieved 2026-08-30 UTC, with the timestamp pinned in the data snapshot. San Francisco’s camera program was funded largely by a $17.3 million state Organized Retail Theft Prevention Grant. Denver’s public checkbook covers recent years, so Denver’s visible spend is a floor, not a total.

These checkbook figures match independent reporting. The San Francisco Standard, working from city contracting documents, reported that SFPD agreed to pay Flock more than $3.9 million for access to its technology between February 20, 2024 and February 19, 2027, which matches the contract row above; the city’s own FY2027 voucher of $1,200,000 shows the annual renewal price. For Denver, the mayor’s office approved a Flock contract for just under $500,000 covering the 110-camera network, per Government Technology and CBS Colorado; the $179,909 visible in the state-published checkbook is the portion of that spending inside the checkbook's window.

$5,191,350

Total vouchers paid by San Francisco to Flock Safety across four fiscal years, FY2024 to FY2027, for the camera contract and the drone contract combined, per dataset n9pm-xkyq. Independently matched by San Francisco Standard reporting.

The scale of the spending matters here. San Francisco's adopted budget is roughly $15.9 billion a year, so $5.19 million paid across four fiscal years is about 0.03 percent of a single year's budget. No city in our panel bought the cameras at a price where cost-effectiveness turns on fine margins. SFPD separately attributes 207 arrests to its Flock ALPRs, including 166 stolen-vehicle arrests. Those are the department's numbers, not ours, and they cannot be verified from open data; for scale, the city logged roughly 11,395 reported thefts in 2024 and 2025 combined, and arrests and thefts are different units.

4. Design and pre-registration

The full methodology was committed to Transparent City's repository (commit `f093c5df`, 2026-08-29) after schema feasibility probes but before any monthly outcome series was assembled or any statistic computed. The rules were fixed before results were seen, and the methodology document is published on this page. In brief:

Panel. Seven cities, monthly reported motor vehicle theft counts by occurrence date, January 2022 to June 2026, from each city's own portal. Treated: San Francisco (network on April 2024), Oakland (on April 2024), Austin (on February 2024 as pre-registered, although the first cameras went live March 29, 2024, so section 6 also reports an April 2024 start; off July 2025), Denver (on April 2024, uncertain by about two months and tested in section 6; off April 2026). Comparisons: Chicago, New York, and Seattle, which are the three cities in Transparent City's coverage without a Flock contract. They were not selected for similarity, and all three run license plate readers from other vendors.

S2, the before and after comparison. For each network switch-on, the mean monthly count in the 12 months before deployment against months 7 to 18 after it, with the identical calendar windows computed for each comparison city. For San Francisco the pre window is April 2023 to March 2024 and the post window is November 2024 to October 2025. The six-month ramp is skipped because San Francisco's cameras were installed between March and July 2024, and months in which only part of the network was live would otherwise count as treated. Switch-offs get no ramp, because removal is immediate: the pre window is the 12 months before the first month off and the post window is every month available since (July 2025 to June 2026 for Austin, April to June 2026 for Denver). The asymmetry favors the switch-on estimate, and section 6 reports the no-ramp version.

S3, the panel model. A difference-in-differences regression, which compares each city with itself over time and with the other cities in the same month: the log of monthly thefts on an indicator for months with an active Flock network, with city and month fixed effects and standard errors clustered by city. Because seven clusters make conventional inference unreliable, significance comes from randomization inference: we reassigned the four camera timelines to the seven cities in every possible way (840 assignments), recomputed the estimate each time, and asked how often chance alone produced an association at least as large as the real one.

S4, event studies. Month-by-month differences between the treated city and the three comparisons, with the month before the event set to zero.

S5, recoveries. Recovered-vehicle counts and recoveries per theft where published (San Francisco, Oakland).

Publication rule. Results are published as computed, favorable or not, in correlational language throughout.

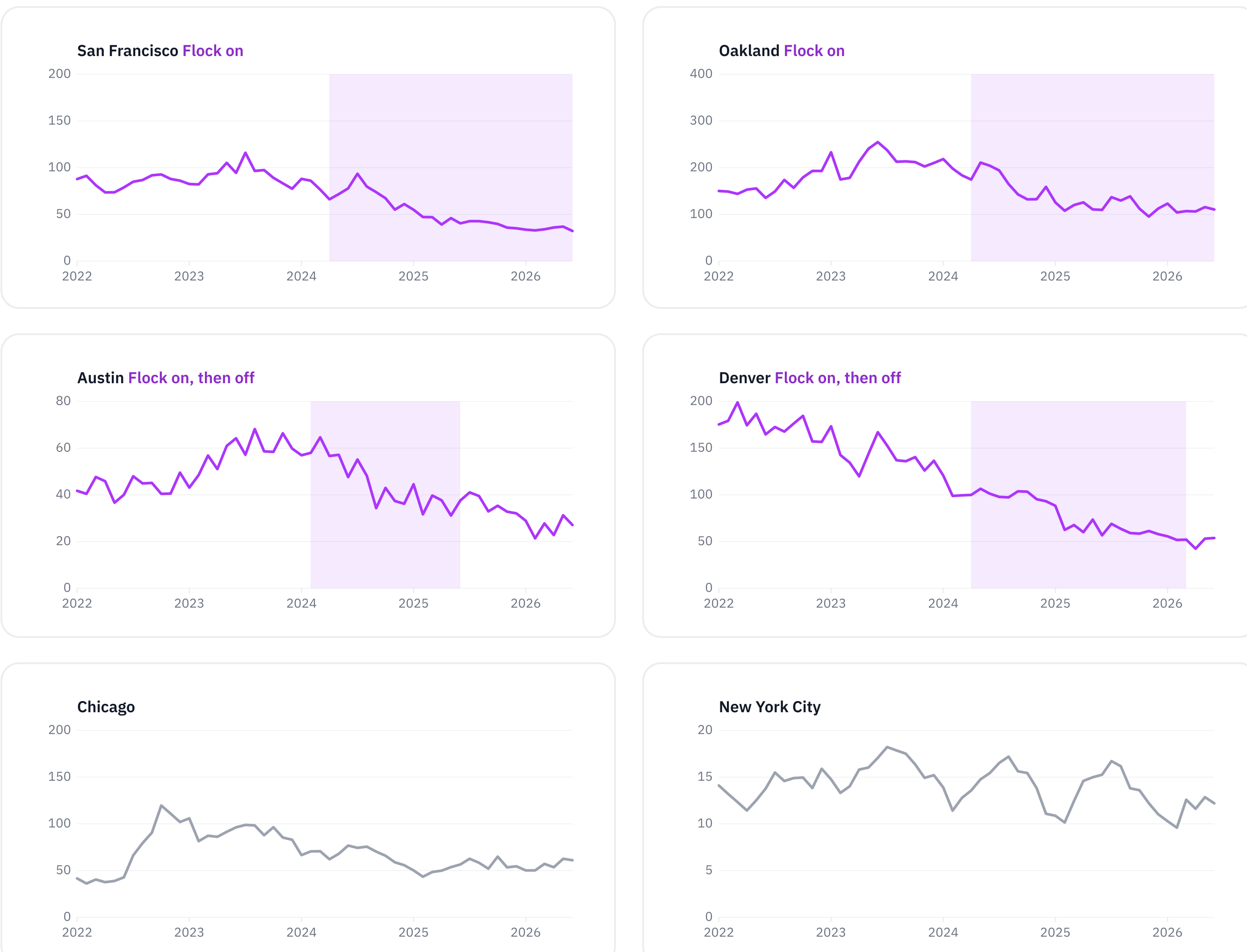
Three items were added after pre-registration and are logged in the methodology's amendments section: the verified Texas DPS install date for Austin (February 2, 2026), the block-level supplement in section 7 (descriptive), and the completion on September 3, 2026 of the robustness variants the pre-registration promised, from the same pinned snapshot.

Part two: The findings

Seven cities, four camera events, one pre-registered set of rules. What happened when networks went on, what happened on the blocks, and what happened when they went off.

5. What the seven cities look like

The panels below show reported thefts per month per 100,000 residents. The shaded band marks the months when each city's Flock network was active.



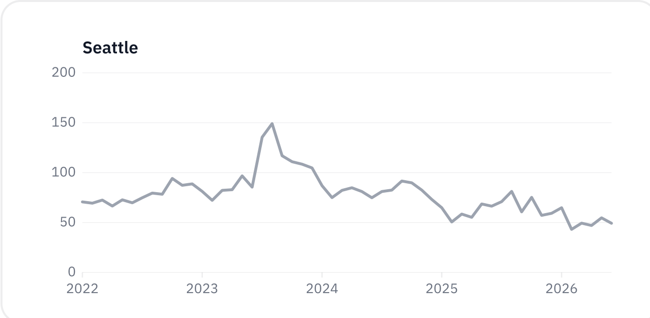


Figure 1. Sources: San Francisco wg3w-h783, Oakland ppgh-7dqv, Austin fdj4-gpfu, Denver ODC_CRIME_OFFENSES_P, Chicago ijzp-q8t2, New York qgea-i56i and 5uac-w243, Seattle tazs-3rd5. Rates use Census Vintage-2023 populations, held constant. Every series declines from its 2023 peak except Denver, which peaked in 2022 and had been falling for a year before its cameras went up, coinciding with Colorado’s felony-theft law. Chicago ticks up in 2026 without any Flock change.

CITY	POPULATION (2023)	2022	2023	2024	2025	2023 TO 2025
San Francisco	808,988	8,225	8,985	7,252	4,143	−53.9%
Oakland	436,504	8,431	11,271	9,234	6,219	−44.8%
Denver	716,577	15,005	12,249	8,723	5,575	−54.5%
Austin	979,882	5,102	6,790	5,829	4,269	−37.1%
Chicago	2,664,452	21,474	29,257	21,713	17,253	−41.0%
New York	8,258,035	13,791	15,780	14,166	13,366	−15.3%
Seattle	755,078	6,978	9,259	7,439	5,799	−37.4%

Annual reported motor vehicle thefts from the pinned snapshot, with the Census Vintage-2023 population estimates used for the per-capita rates. The two dense always-on Flock cities sit at the top of the range alongside Denver, whose decline has non-Flock explanations documented above.

6. After deployment: reported theft fell faster in the two dense-network cities

This section carries the favorable evidence and its uncertainty.

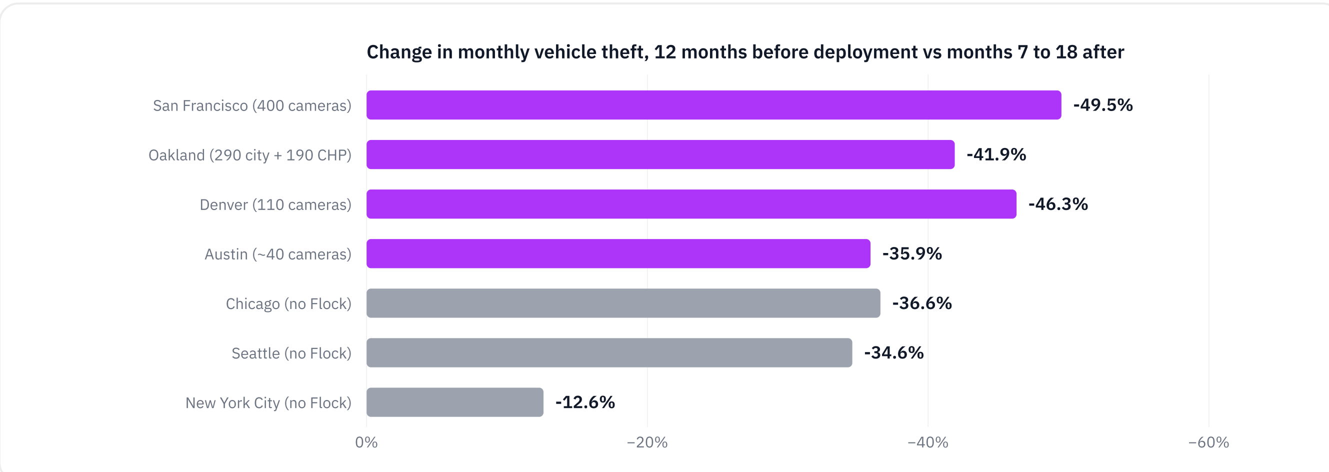


Figure 2. Purple bars are cities with an active Flock network; gray bars are the three comparison cities over the same calendar window. Specification S2.

NETWORK SWITCH-ON	THEFTS PER MONTH, 12 MONTHS BEFORE	THEFTS PER MONTH, MONTHS 7 TO 18 AFTER	CHANGE	CHICAGO	NEW YORK	SEATTLE	CHANGE WITH 1 TO 12)
San Francisco on (2024-04)	744.1	375.7	−49.5%	−36.6%	−12.6%	−34.6%	−30.4% (compar
Oakland on (2024-04)	944.4	548.7	−41.9%	−36.6%	−12.6%	−34.6%	−29.9% (compar
Denver on (2024-04)	942.3	505.9	−46.3%	−36.6%	−12.6%	−34.6%	−31.8% (compar
Austin on (2024-02, about 40 cameras)	577.2	370.2	−35.9%	−36.4%	−12.1%	−30.8%	−21.3% (compar

Mean monthly reported thefts citywide. Comparison-city columns apply the identical calendar windows. The last column is the pre-registered robustness variant with no ramp skip; in the first twelve months San Francisco's decline (−30.4%) is only slightly ahead of Chicago (−28.5%) and Seattle (−28.3%), so the head start reported in this section appears in months 7 to 18, not in the first year. Denver's row carries the Colorado confounders from section 2. San Francisco's cameras arrived bundled with the Real-Time Investigation Center, drones, and staffing changes, and the contributions cannot be separated.

The pattern is consistent with camera density mattering. San Francisco (400 cameras, about 49 per 100,000 residents) and Oakland (290 city cameras plus 190 California Highway Patrol cameras on highways) outfell every comparison city. Austin, whose pilot amounted to roughly 40 cameras in a city of about a million people, tracked Chicago and Seattle closely.

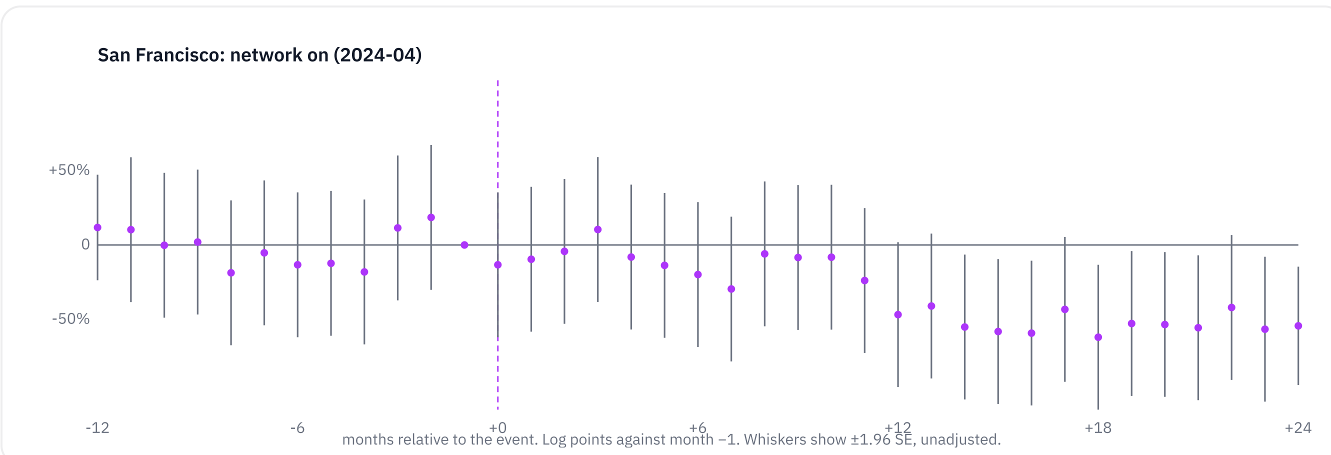
The panel model summarizes the same contrast. Across all seven cities, months with an active Flock network show **18.2 percent lower reported theft** than city and calendar effects predict (coefficient -0.201, standard error clustered by city 0.115). A conventional 95 percent interval runs from roughly −34.7% to +2.6%, and with seven clusters even that interval is unreliable, which is why the permutation test is the primary check. Under it the estimate does not clear conventional significance ($p = 0.157$); an association this size arises by chance about one time in six. The robustness variants promised in the pre-registration are all reported below.

SPECIFICATION	ASSOCIATION	PERMUTATION P	NOTE
Primary (all seven cities, log counts)	−18.2%	0.157	Pre-registered main specification
Excluding Austin	−26.4%	0.017	Drops the roughly 40-camera network; 360 permutations
Excluding Denver	−14.2%	0.183	Drops the city with an uncertain start date and a confounded decline
San Francisco start moved to July 2024	−17.4%	0.148	Full deployment instead of first installs
Denver start moved to February 2024	−18.8%	0.129	Denver S2 change −43.4%
Denver start moved to June 2024	−17.2%	0.169	Denver S2 change −48.8%
Austin start moved to April 2024 (first cameras live March 29, 2024)	Austin S2 change −38.6%	not applicable	Comparisons −36.6%, −12.6%, −34.6%
Winsorized at each city’s 1st and 99th percentile	−18.3%	0.148	Limits the influence of extreme months
Levels instead of logs	-53.5 thefts per month	not tested	Coefficient in monthly thefts; no permutation run for this variant

Every variant lands between −14.2% and −26.4%. Only the variant that drops Austin clears p = 0.05. The no-ramp before and after comparison appears in the table above.

How to state this finding

"In the two cities that deployed dense Flock networks and kept them, reported vehicle theft fell roughly 42 to 50 percent over months 7 to 18 after deployment, more than in any of three large comparison cities over the same months. A seven-city panel puts the association at 14 to 26 percent depending on specification, at the edge of what so small a panel can statistically distinguish from coincidence. It is an association consistent with the cameras helping, bundled with everything else those cities did at the same time. It is not proof."



Figures 3 and 4. Event studies (S4): the month-by-month difference in reported theft between the treated city and the three comparison cities, on a log scale, with the month before the event set to zero. San Francisco reaches roughly 55 percent below its pre-event relationship by month 24; Oakland's post-event months range roughly 10 to 45 percent below. Whiskers are unadjusted 95 percent intervals.

7. The view from the block

Transparent City’s product is built around a promise: your block, not just your city. So this section takes the San Francisco result down to street level, using the same public data. It was added after pre-registration and is labeled as a supplement, and it is descriptive.

The DeFlock project crowdsources camera locations onto OpenStreetMap, and its volunteers have mapped 333 SFPD Flock camera positions in San Francisco, about 83 percent of the 400-camera network. We measured the straight-line distance from each geocoded theft incident to the nearest mapped camera. Of 30,807 incidents in the window, 390 lacked coordinates and were excluded, leaving 30,417. SFPD publishes incident points snapped to intersections or block faces rather than exact addresses, so the distance bands are approximate. We then compared the twelve months before deployment (April 2023 to March 2024) with the post-ramp period (October 2024 to June 2026), on camera blocks (within 250 meters of a camera) and away from them (500 meters or more from every camera).

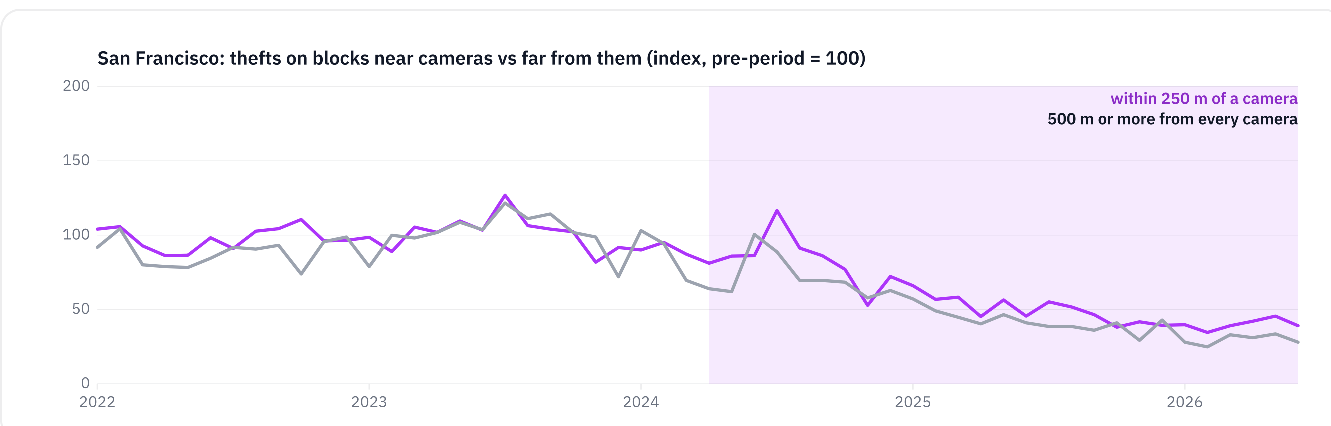


Figure 5. Monthly reported thefts within each band, indexed so the April 2023 to March 2024 average equals 100. Camera locations: OpenStreetMap contributors via the DeFlock project, retrieved 2026-08-31. The 250 to 500 meter buffer band is excluded.

–50% / –59%

The decline in monthly reported theft on blocks within 250 meters of a mapped camera, and on blocks 500 meters or more from every camera. The falls are nearly identical, and slightly larger away from the cameras.

Two things are visible here. First, the cameras sit where the problem was: blocks near cameras ran 292 reported thefts per month before deployment against 161 on distant blocks, consistent with SFPD's stated placement on high-traffic corridors and entry routes. Second, the decline is citywide, not concentrated around camera sites. Reported theft on camera blocks fell 50.4 percent; reported theft far from every camera fell 58.5 percent.

The teaching point is that fixed license plate readers are not scarecrows. If these cameras contributed to San Francisco's decline, the geography is more consistent with an investigative network that identifies vehicles and closes cases across the whole city than with frightening thieves away from particular corners. That reading matches the randomized studies, which found no localized deterrence, and it matches what SFPD itself claims, which is arrests rather than deterrence. It also means block-level camera maps are a poor guide to where any benefit lands.

Every high-theft neighborhood logged fewer thefts

The same incident data, grouped by the city's analysis neighborhoods, shows the before and after for every part of San Francisco. All 18 neighborhoods that logged at least 200 reported thefts in 2023 recorded fewer in 2025, with declines between 37 and 69 percent.

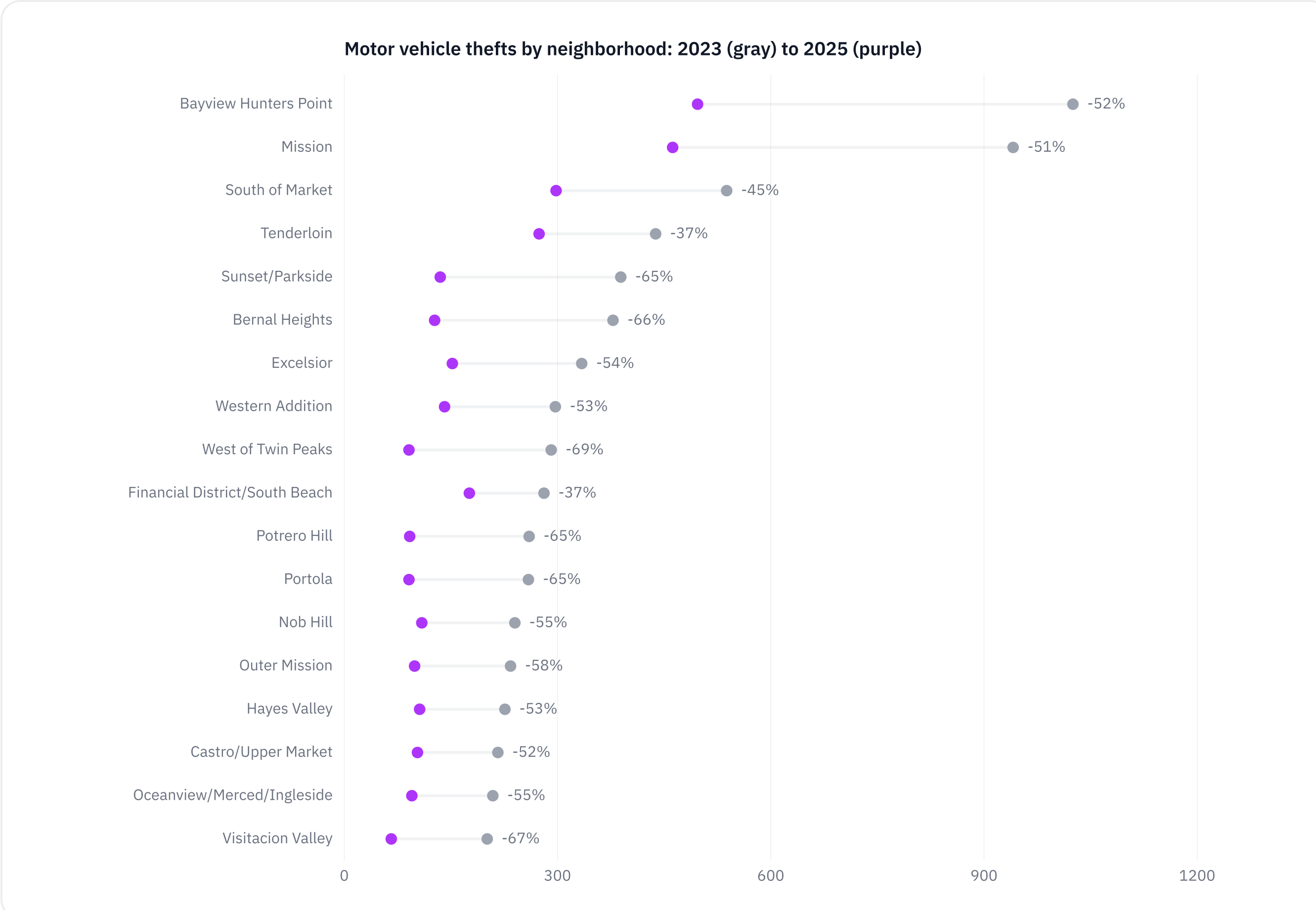


Figure 6. Neighborhoods with at least 200 reported thefts in 2023, ordered by 2023 volume. Gray marks 2023; purple marks 2025. Source: wg3w-h783, analysis_neighborhood field.

NEIGHBORHOOD	2023	2025	CHANGE
Bayview Hunters Point	1,025	497	−51.5%
Mission	941	462	−50.9%
South of Market	538	298	−44.6%
Tenderloin	438	274	−37.4%
Sunset/Parkside	389	135	−65.3%
Bernal Heights	378	127	−66.4%
Excelsior	334	152	−54.5%
Western Addition	297	141	−52.5%
West of Twin Peaks	291	91	−68.7%
Financial District/South Beach	281	176	−37.4%
Potrero Hill	260	92	−64.6%
Portola	259	91	−64.9%
Nob Hill	240	109	−54.6%
Outer Mission	234	99	−57.7%
Hayes Valley	226	106	−53.1%
Castro/Upper Market	216	103	−52.3%
Oceanview/Merced/Ingleside	209	95	−54.5%
Visitacion Valley	201	66	−67.2%

The steepest declines are in residential districts on the west and south sides, and the smallest are in the dense core. That gradient fits the national story in section 2, in which the Kia and Hyundai wave that had made street-parked cars in residential neighborhoods easy targets receded after software fixes.

8. The off-switch: no rebound, so far

If dense camera networks were suppressing vehicle theft in real time, switching them off should show up in the data. Two cities switched their networks off, which is the closest thing to that test the public record offers, and this is the finding that disciplines the pro-camera case.

Austin shut its city network down on June 30, 2025. In the pre-registered comparison, the twelve months after the shutoff against the twelve before, reported thefts fell 21.8 percent, faster than any comparison city. Because Texas DPS installed state-owned Flock readers along Austin rights-of-way on February 2, 2026, a post-hoc supplement also reports the clean seven-month window, July 2025 to January 2026, in which Austin fell 12.7 percent, again faster than any comparison city. Austin's roughly 40-camera network was small enough that little should have been expected of its removal.

AUSTIN SWITCH-OFF WINDOW	THEFTS PER MONTH BEFORE	THEFTS PER MONTH AFTER	AUSTIN	CHICAGO	NEW YORK	SEATTLE
Pre-registered: July 2025 to June 2026	388.8	304.2	−21.8%	−3.1%	−9.1%	−17.6%
Clean window, post-hoc: July 2025 to January 2026	388.8	339.3	−12.7%	−3.4%	−4.3%	−7.0%

Mean monthly reported thefts; comparison columns use the identical calendar windows.

−12.7%

Change in Austin's monthly reported vehicle theft during its seven clean months with the Flock network off, a faster decline than any comparison city over the same months.

Denver went dark at the end of March 2026. Three post months are observable, April to June 2026, with 303, 381, and 385 reported thefts against a prior-year mean of 429.2 per month, which is **down 17.0 percent**, roughly matching Seattle (−19.7%) while Chicago rose (+6.9%). The three months rise from April to May; Denver's count also rose from April to May in 2024 and in 2025, so on three points this is seasonal noise rather than a trend. Three months is a short window, and criminals' knowledge of camera removal may lag the removal itself.

Figures 7 and 8. Event studies around the switch-off events. Austin's post-shutoff differences sit at or below zero, and Denver's three post months are unremarkable.

What this means for the argument

The strongest version of the pro-camera case, that removing the cameras brings theft back, is not supported by the first two natural experiments available, within short windows. The defensible pro-camera case is the investigative one (section 3): the cameras are cheap, police departments attribute concrete arrests to them, and dense deployments coincided with outsized declines. Anyone claiming Denver or Austin “paid in crime” for canceling is, on present evidence, wrong, and this report will not say it.

9. Recoveries

San Francisco's incident data records recovered vehicles alongside thefts: 7,413 recovery reports from April 2024 to June 2026. The ratio of recovery reports to theft reports was roughly 0.72 in the pre-camera period (January 2022 to March 2024) and 0.67 after the ramp (October 2024 to June 2026). Recoveries fell in proportion with thefts rather than rising as a share. The categories count incident reports, including vehicles stolen elsewhere and recovered in San Francisco, so the ratio is a rough gauge. It is worth stating plainly because "more recoveries" is a common vendor claim, and San Francisco's open data shows fewer thefts and proportionally fewer recovery reports, not a rising recovery rate. Oakland's recovery-labeled categories show a flat ratio near 0.11 throughout, and its category taxonomy differs too much from San Francisco's for comparison.

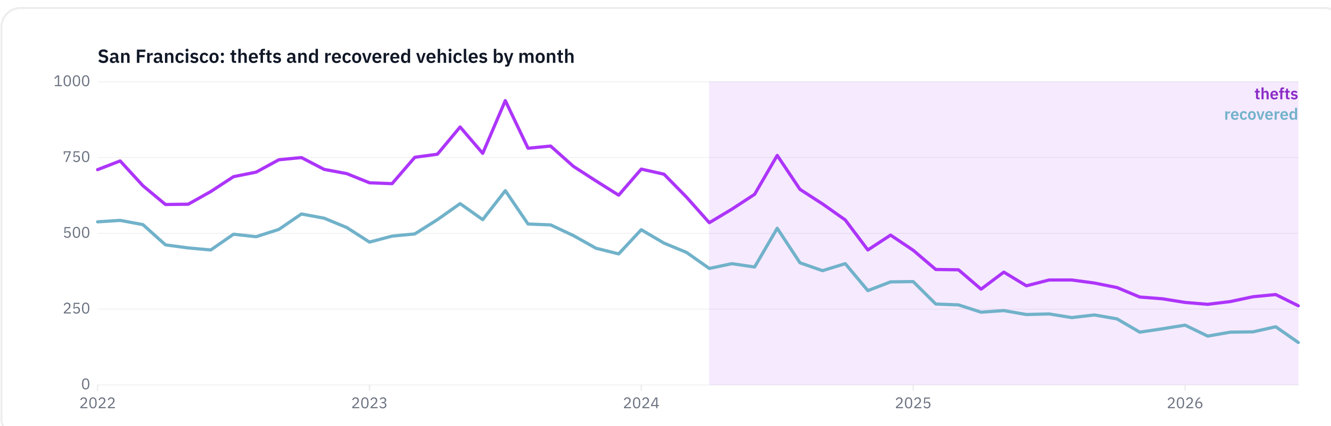


Figure 9. San Francisco monthly reported thefts (purple) and recovered-vehicle incidents (blue), with the deployment period shaded. Source: wg3w-h783.

Part three: Reading the evidence

Where every number comes from, what the data cannot tell us, the governance record, and the conclusion the evidence supports.

10. Data, downloads, and queries

Every number on this page traces to a public dataset. The pinned snapshot, the results, the methodology, the analysis scripts, and the PDF edition are published here so that nothing depends on access to Transparent City's systems.

monthly_series.csv
(transparent.city/reports/flock/monthly_series.csv)
Seven cities, monthly reported thefts and per-100k rates, plus recovery series

flock_payments.csv
(transparent.city/reports/flock/flock_payments.csv)
Every San Francisco and Denver payment and contract row used

flock_snapshot.json
(transparent.city/reports/flock/flock_snapshot.json)
Raw pinned snapshot with the UTC retrieval timestamp

analysis_results.json
(transparent.city/reports/flock/analysis_results.json)
Every statistic in this report, as computed

block_supplement.json
(transparent.city/reports/flock/block_supplement.json)
Section 7 near/far bands and neighborhood counts

METHODOLOGY.md
(transparent.city/reports/flock/METHODOLOGY.md)
The pre-registered methodology with its amendments log

pull_data.py (transparent.city/reports/flock/pull_data.py), analyze.py (transparent.city/reports/flock/analyze.py), block_analysis.py (transparent.city/reports/flock/block_analysis.py), build_charts.py (transparent.city/reports/flock/build_charts.py)
The analysis code, in run order

Flock-by-the-Numbers.pdf
(transparent.city/reports/flock/Flock-by-the-Numbers.pdf)
Print edition of this report

Each series below links to the live portal query that produced it.

SERIES	PORTAL	DATASET	FILTER
San Francisco thefts	data.sfgov.org	`wg3w-h783`	`incident_category = 'Motor Vehicle Theft'`
San Francisco recovered vehicles	data.sfgov.org	`wg3w-h783`	`incident_category = 'Recovered Vehicle'`
San Francisco payments	data.sfgov.org	`n9pm-xkyq`	`vendor = 'FLOCK SAFETY'`
San Francisco contracts	data.sfgov.org	`cqi5-hm2d`	`prime_contractor like '%FLOCK%'`
Oakland thefts	data.oaklandca.gov	`ppgh-7dqv`	`crimetype = 'STOLEN VEHICLE'`
Austin thefts	data.austintexas.gov	`fdj4-gpfu`	`crime_type = 'AUTO THEFT'`
Denver thefts	denvergov.org (ArcGIS)	`ODC_CRIME_OFFENSES_P, layer 324`	`OFFENSE_CATEGORY_ID = 'auto-theft'`
Denver payments	data.colorado.gov	`wnau-xrqi`	`payee = 'FLOCK SAFETY'`
Chicago thefts	data.cityofchicago.org	`ijzp-q8t2`	`primary_type = 'MOTOR VEHICLE THEFT'`
Chicago payments (zero check)	data.cityofchicago.org	`s4vu-giwb`	`vendor_name like '%FLOCK SAFETY%' or '%FLOCK GROUP%'`
New York thefts, through 2025	data.cityofnewyork.us	`qgea-i56i`	`ofns_desc = 'GRAND LARCENY OF MOTOR VEHICLE'`
New York thefts, 2026	data.cityofnewyork.us	`5uac-w243`	`ofns_desc = 'GRAND LARCENY OF MOTOR VEHICLE'`
Seattle thefts	data.seattle.gov	`tazs-3rd5`	`nibrs_offense_code = '240'`
San Francisco camera locations (supplement)	OpenStreetMap via the DeFlock project	`Overpass API nodes`	`man_made=surveillance, ALPR, operator SFPD or brand Flock Safety`

All counts are by occurrence date, citywide, monthly. Police data back-fills, so trailing months may rise in later refreshes; the panel ends June 2026 for this reason.

11. Limitations

Read these before quoting anything above.

Small N, stated in our own voice. Seven cities and four treatment events. No specification here identifies a causal effect, and the permutation test exists precisely because seven clusters make conventional inference unreliable.

No causal identification. San Francisco's cameras arrived with a real-time crime center, drones, and staffing changes, and the contributions cannot be separated. The randomized literature on license plate reader deterrence, which predates Flock's dense fixed networks, found null effects, and nothing here overturns it.

The head start depends on the window. With no ramp skip, San Francisco's first-year decline is only slightly ahead of Chicago and Seattle (section 6). The larger gap appears in months 7 to 18.

The national wave dominates. The Kia and Hyundai correction and record national declines moved every series. Comparison cities absorb this only imperfectly because the wave hit cities unevenly, and New York's smaller decline widens the comparison range.

Comparison cities were not chosen for similarity. Chicago, New York, and Seattle are the Flock-free cities in Transparent City's coverage. All three run license plate readers from other vendors, so the contrast is "dense Flock fixed network" against "other arrangements," not cameras against none.

Off-windows are short. Denver has three months. Austin has seven clean months before state-installed Flock cameras recontaminate the city. Both series will be re-run as data accumulates; see the update log below.

Reported crime is not crime. Vehicle theft is among the best-reported offenses because insurance requires a report, which is why it is the outcome. It still undercounts.

Denver's start date is approximate (about two months either way, tested in section 6), and its checkbook window means its Flock spend is a floor.

The block-level supplement is descriptive and post-hoc. Camera coordinates are crowdsourced and cover about 83 percent of the network; incident points are snapped to intersections; distance bands are coarse; cameras were placed on the highest-theft corridors, so near and far blocks differ at baseline.

Category taxonomies differ across cities. Counts are never compared in levels across cities; only within-city changes are.

12. The governance ledger

The favorable numbers above are only credible next to a plain accounting of the criticisms, so here it is. The case against Flock in 2025 and 2026 was not that the cameras do not work. It was: local police running immigration-related lookups through Flock's national network despite state law (NPR, February 2026); an Illinois Secretary of State audit in August 2025 finding that Customs and Border Protection accessed Illinois cameras through an undisclosed pilot (Capitol News Illinois); SFPD's own June 2026 audit finding 299 unauthorized searches of its data, including improper federal access (Mission Local); and officers criminally charged with using the system to track ex-partners (WBEZ, August 2026). A federal judge in Norfolk nonetheless held a 176-camera network constitutional in January 2026, a ruling now on appeal, and Flock's August 2026 reforms, which cut the recommended default retention from 30 days to 7 (existing customers keep their settings) and will require a case code on every search by the end of the year, answered several criticisms directly. National cancellation tallies come from advocacy trackers and are labeled as such.

Our data adds one observation to this ledger: the cities that canceled over these governance failures have not, so far, seen a measurable rise in reported vehicle theft. Cities that keep the cameras are paying little for them; whether they are buying investigative capability is a claim only the departments can make. Either way, they owe their residents the audit discipline that San Francisco's own review showed was missing.

13. Conclusion

Strip away the advocacy on both sides and the public record supports three sentences. Flock's cameras cost the cities in our panel remarkably little: $5,191,350 across four fiscal years in San Francisco, $179,909 visible in Denver's checkbook, and zero in Chicago. Where networks were dense, reported vehicle theft fell farther and faster than in three large comparison cities, an association of 14 to 26 percent in our panel that is present in every specification but statistically fragile in the pre-registered one. And where the cameras were switched off, reported theft kept falling, which retires the strongest claim made on the cameras' behalf while leaving intact the modest, checkable one: a cheap tool, concrete department-attributed arrests, outsized coincident declines, and governance, not effectiveness, as the thing the fights should be about.

14. References and reproduction

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Reproduction: download the four scripts and the snapshot in section 10. Running `pull_data.py` then `analyze.py` regenerates every number on this page from the live portals; trailing months will differ slightly as police data back-fills. The page source is public in the Transparent City Ui repository.

About Transparent City

Transparent City uses AI and public data to make civic information legible, understandable, and actionable for everyday residents. The service ingests the official open-data portals of the cities it covers, including payments, contracts, payroll, police incidents, and service requests, normalizes millions of records, and turns them into plain-language reporting that links every number back to the dataset it came from. Its editorial rule for this report, as for all its reporting, is simple: no manufactured certainty, and no conclusions the data does not support.

Version, updates, and corrections

Version 1.0, published September 2026. Data retrieved 2026-08-30 UTC; panel through June 2026. Author: Transparent City (Adam Werbach); analysis and drafting assisted by Claude, with every number traced to the pinned snapshot above. Independent of Flock Safety, its investors, and campaign organizations on all sides; no non-public data was used.

This page is the canonical edition of the report. It will be refreshed as the cities publish more months, without changing any pre-registered specification; each refresh bumps the version and is logged here. Corrections are made in place and noted below with the date. Send corrections to seymour@transparent.city.

How to cite: Transparent City, “Flock by the Numbers,” version 1.0, September 2026, transparent.city/reports/flock.

- Version 1.0 (September 2026): first publication. Pre-review corrections applied before release: neighborhood count (18, not 14), camera-map coverage (about 83 percent), geocoded incident count, the four-fiscal-year payment span, and the drone share of San Francisco’s total.